'I Keep Things Authentic'

If you follow actor **Gul Panag** on social media, you should know that she has the same mantra for her posts and her travels—always keep it real!

Q. How has the pandemic changed your travel philosophy?
We were always outdoorsy, but now the scales are tipping in favour of camping and road trips. We are seeking our unique, safe experiences that centre around the outdoors.

Q. Is there one trip from recent times that has been deeply memorable?
Earlier this year, we went to Ranthambore for a family trip with my parents and my brother and his wife. Being together as a family in these uncertain times gave us much to be grateful for... that, and my son saw his first tiger!

Q. A lot of your trips seem to centre around driving. How does that change the itinerary?
A lot more camping, for starters! My father got a large new tent to operate as a family common area, to supplement our existing tents. In addition, we plan trips around standalone boutique properties and homestays.

Q. Did social media change the way you travel? Do you ever look at new things through Instagram eyes?
Not really. I have been travelling way before Instagram came along. It's a place to capture and chronicle memories (and perhaps discover new places). For me, social media has always been a reflection of the real me, not the curated me. I like to keep things authentic.

Q. Travelling solo versus travelling with family... what do you yearn for?
Travelling with family, for sure. Notwithstanding the insane coordination of the schedules it involves, travelling together as a family is pure joy. As mom to a three-year-old, the reality of solo trips is clear to me—worrying about him the whole time. I would rather have him with me!

Q. If you had to pick three winter destinations for our readers this year, which would they be?
The hills around Shimla. They are easy to get to, there are many options and there is snow. Ranthambore—desert winters mean you can really soak in the sun. Tigers are a bonus, if you get lucky. And Moscow—easy to get to, no embargo on travel, and, yes, the architecture!

–with Sandeep Unnithan



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